

Morocco

 A mix of African, Islamic, Arab, Berber, and European influences, Morocco attracts more than four million tourists each year. The country's strengths are farming and phosphate mining. Founded in Fès, in AD 859, Karuein University is the oldest in the world.



Mint tea

The traditional drink in Morocco is a refreshing mint tea, served in glasses or pots, with plenty of sugar and a sprig of mint. It is often offered free of charge in the *souks* (markets), when bargaining is about to begin.

Carpets

Hand-knotted woollen carpets are one of Morocco's great craft industries. The leading carpet factories are in Fès and Rabat. The carpets have bold colours and symbolic, abstract Islamic patterns. Though sold by men, most rugs are made by women.



Western Sahara

Morocco has occupied the ex-Spanish colony of Western Sahara since 1975. Polisario Front guerrillas began fighting for independence in 1983, to resist mass settlement of the area by Moroccans keen to hold on to the phosphate-rich territory.



Polisario soldiers keep watch

Tunisia

 A former French colony, Tunisia is the smallest country in the region and one of the more liberal Arab states. Although not admitted into politics, Tunisian women enjoy a high level of equality, making up 31 per cent of the work-force.

Couscous is steamed in a special pot that sits above the stewing meat.



Couscous

The staple food in Tunisia is granules of semolina called couscous. Originally a Berber dish, couscous is served with a meat or vegetable sauce. Tunisians like their food spicy. After this main course, dates stuffed with almond paste, or sweet pastries filled with honey and nuts are served.

Souk

A feature of Tunisian cities – and indeed all northwest African cities – is the *souk*, or market. This is traditionally a tangle of narrow streets flanked by open-fronted stalls, where people can buy anything from food to carpets or hand-made jewellery.



MOROCCO FACTS

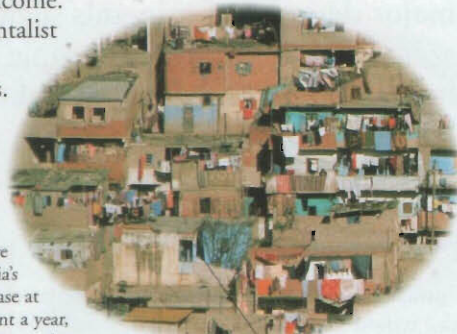
CAPITAL CITY	Rabat
AREA	446,300 sq km (172,316 sq miles)
POPULATION	28,400,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	Arabic, Berber, French
MAJOR RELIGION	Muslim
CURRENCY	Moroccan dirham

Algeria

 Under French rule from 1830, Algeria won independence in 1962. The country has a high birth rate and a young population: 86 per cent are below the age of 44. Crude oil and natural gas are an important source of income. Increasingly, fundamentalist Islamic groups pose a threat to non-Muslims.

Overpopulation

Since more than four-fifths of Algeria is desert, 90 per cent of Algerians live in the far north of the country, where it is cooler. However, as Algeria's population continues to increase at a rate of more than 1.7 per cent a year, many northern towns, like Constantine, are struggling to house everybody, and slum areas are growing.



Black dates

Houses are built on every available piece of land.



Yellow dates

Dates

Algeria is the world's sixth largest producer of dates. They are grown in the fertile north as well as in the many oases of the Sahara, and provide a main source of income. Date palms also yield timber; their leaves are used to thatch buildings.

Libya

 Since 95 per cent of Libya is desert, the Great Man-made River Project was set up to irrigate farming land. Water is piped from beneath the Sahara to populated coastal regions.

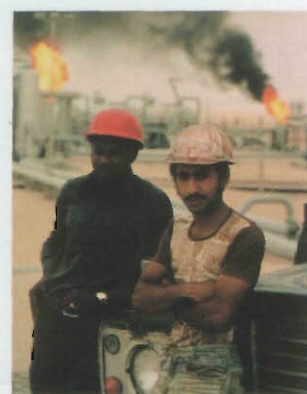
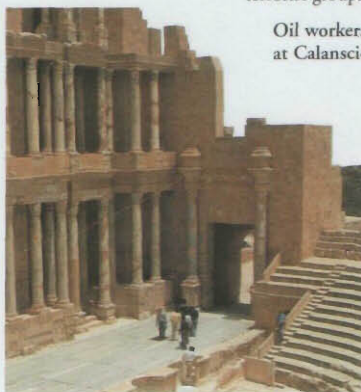
LIBYA FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Tripoli
AREA	1,759,540 sq km (679,358 sq miles)
POPULATION	5,600,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	Arabic, Tuareg
MAJOR RELIGION	Muslim
CURRENCY	Libyan dinar

Oil and gas

The discovery of oil and natural gas in 1959 transformed Libya into a wealthy nation, and many people moved to the towns in search of work. In 1992, trade with the West was severely disrupted when the UN imposed sanctions because of leader Colonel Gaddafi's alleged links with international terrorist groups.

Oil workers at Calanscio



Roman ruins

Libya was abandoned by the Romans after the Arab conquest of AD 643 and was an Italian colony between 1911 and 1951. Today, some of the finest Roman ruins outside Italy can be seen at Leptis Magna, now called Ladbah, to the east of the capital, Tripoli.

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